

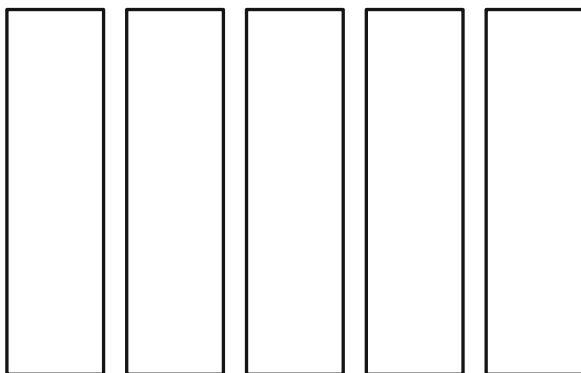
Building the Grid

The 12-Point System

A grid you only talked about last class is still just an idea. Tonight it becomes something your file actually holds you to.

Three Ways to Grid a Page

Every page layout system rests on one of a handful of basic grid types. These three are the ones that matter for a portfolio.



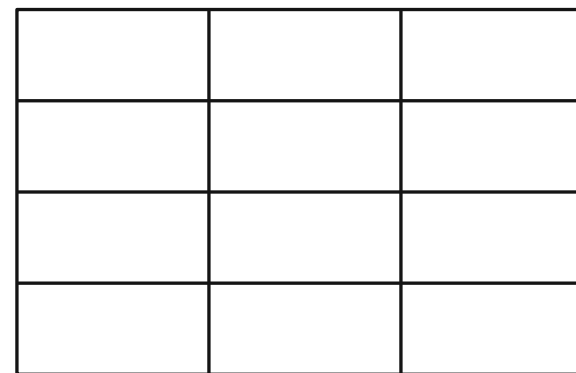
Column Grid

Vertical strips divide the page.
Content flows down within a column.



Baseline Grid

A fine horizontal rule every
twelve points. Text locks to it.



Modular Grid

Columns and rows together.
The page divides into modules.

A column grid alone gives images nowhere specific to land. A baseline grid alone organizes text but not images. A portfolio carrying drawings, renderings, and text together needs the modular grid, and tonight, it needs the baseline grid running underneath it too.

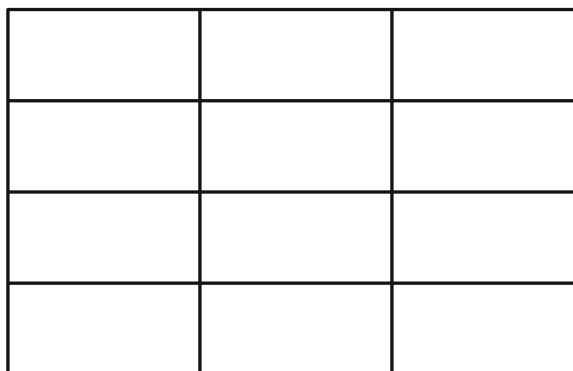
Two Grids, Aligned

A baseline grid alone. A modular grid alone. Combined, they're the discipline that makes a portfolio look considered instead of assembled.



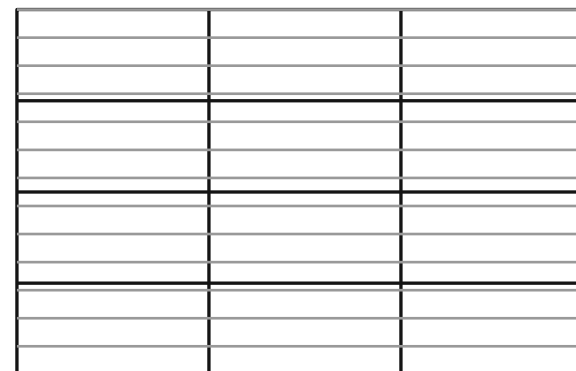
Baseline Grid

Fine ruled lines every
12 points. Text locks here.



Modular Grid

The coarse field of
columns and rows. Blocks live here.



Both, Combined

One file, one unit,
governing both.

Choose Your Leading First

A column grid can wing it, the leading can flex. A modular grid can't: the leading is the building block every other measurement is built from, so it has to be decided before anything else, not adjusted after the fact.

THE RULE

Pick a round, easily divisible number. 10 and 12 both work.

Why This Class Uses 12

Twelve divides cleanly by two, three, four, and six. It also leaves room for a 9.5–10pt body text size, the range most designers treat as optimal for running text. Ten would force a different, less flexible type scale.

Leading, Visualized

Leading is the distance from one line's baseline to the next, measured top to bottom, not the space between letters and not the type size itself.

12 pt

Every drawing in this portfolio sits on the
same twelve point rhythm. The grid holds
the page together, line by line.

STEP 2

Set the Document Size

Once the leading is fixed, the page height has to be a whole multiple of it. Not close. Exact.

1

Preferences > Units & Increments: set Ruler Units to Points

2

File > New Document: Width 600pt, Height 840pt

3

Facing Pages on · 14 pages (7 spreads)

840 / 12 = 70, no remainder. That's the whole reason this page size, not some other one, is correct for a 12-point system.

New Document

Width: 600 pt

Height: 840 pt

Pages: 14

☒ Facing Pages

OK

Good Numbers, Bad Numbers

Once the leading is set, every later measurement gets checked against it by hand. Here's what passing and failing that check looks like.

Checked against a 12pt leading



divides evenly by 12

$$36 / 12 = 3$$

$$48 / 12 = 4$$

$$72 / 12 = 6$$

$$600 / 12 = 50$$

$$840 / 12 = 70$$



leaves a remainder

$$40 / 12 = 3.33$$

$$50 / 12 = 4.17$$

$$35 / 12 = 2.92$$

$$100 / 12 = 8.33$$

A number in the right column isn't close enough to round up or down later. It means stop, rethink the measurement, before it becomes a margin, a row, or a column setting.

STEP 3

Set the Margins

Margins have to be multiples of 12 too, or the rows won't divide evenly no matter what you do later.

MARGIN	VALUE	x12
Top	36 pt	3 x 12
Bottom	48 pt	4 x 12
In/Out	36 pt	3 x 12

The trap: a margin like 40pt looks reasonable, but 40 isn't divisible by 12. Build a grid on top of that and you get 3.333 rows instead of a whole number, impossible to align.

Margins and Columns

Top:

36 pt

12 x 3

Bottom:

48 pt

12 x 4

Inside/Outside:

36 pt

OK

STEP 4

Turn On the Baseline Grid

View > Grids & Guides > Show Baseline Grid. Then fix the one setting everyone misses.

THE GOTCHA

By default the baseline grid only appears once you're zoomed to 75% or more. Zoom out and it vanishes, it isn't gone, you just can't see it.

The Fix

Preferences > Grids > View Threshold: change it to 25%, so the grid stays visible at any reasonable zoom level while you work.

Optional

Grid color: light gray reads calmer than the default blue while you're placing content.

Preferences > Grids

Start:	0 pt
Relative To:	Top Margin
Increment Every:	12 pt
View Threshold:	25%

OK

Do the Row Math

Before touching Create Guides, confirm the numbers actually fit. Three lines, no guessing.

- 1** **Page height minus margins: $840 - 36 - 48 = 756$ pt of content height**
- 2** **Divide by the baseline increment: $756 / 12 = 63$ whole baseline lines, no remainder**
- 3** **8 rows of 7 content lines each, plus 7 gutters of 1 line each: $(8 \times 7) + (7 \times 1) = 63$, exact fit**

STEP 6

Create the Guides

The math already checked out, so this dialog just executes it.

1 **Layout > Create Guides**

2 **Rows and Columns each get their own Number and Gutter**

3 **Fit Guides to: Margins, then click OK**

Create Guides

Rows		Columns	
Number:	8	Number:	6
Gutter:	12 pt	Gutter:	12 pt

Options

Fit Guides to: ☒ **Margins** ☐ Page

☐ Remove Existing Ruler Guides

Close the Loop on Paragraph Styles

Last class, Body Text was built but deliberately left unfinished, Align to Grid needed a baseline that didn't exist yet. It exists now.

THE ONE SETTING THAT WAS WAITING

Window > Styles > Paragraph Styles, double-click Body Text, then Indents and Spacing.

Align to Grid: All Lines

Lines of Body Text across two different columns will now perfectly match up, line for line, even though they were typed independently. This is the alignment principle made literal in the software, and it only applies to your real project file, the test file has no Body Text to align.

The Whole System, One Page

Every setting from tonight, on one page, so you can see what each number is actually for.

PHASE 2
Technical Execution of the "Atomic Unit"

- 1 **Document Setup**
Units: Points | Width: 600pt | Height: 840pt | 14 pages (7 spreads) | Facing Pages
- 2 **Baseline Grid**
Preferences > Grids | Start: 0pt (Top Margin) | Increment: 12pt | View > Show Baseline Grid
- 3 **Margins & Columns**
Layout > Margins and Columns | Top: 36pt | Bottom: 48pt | Inside/Outside: 36pt | 6 columns, 12pt gutter
- 4 **Modular Grid (Rows)**
Layout > Create Guides | 8 rows, 12pt gutter | Fit Guides to: Margins | Result: 7 content lines + 1 gutter

Preferences > Grids

Start:

Relative To:

Increment Every:

OK

A

➡

Margins and Columns

Top: (12x3)

Bottom: (12x4)

Inside/Outside:

Columns: Gutter:

OK

B

➡

Layout > Create Guides

Rows:

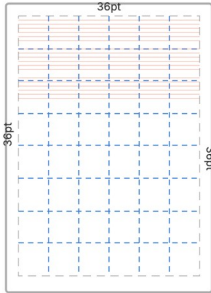
Gutter:

Fit Guides to:

OK

C

Result: 600 x 840pt Page with Both Grids Active



Modular Grid
6 columns + 8 rows (blue)

Baseline Grid
70 lines at 12pt (orange)

Margins
36 / 48 / 36 / 36pt (dashed)

— Modular grid (6 cols + 8 rows) — Baseline grid (12pt increment)

A Note on Printing

600×840pt is the easiest version of this system to learn: every number divides cleanly, and the row math has zero remainder. It's not, however, a real sheet of paper.

IF YOU'RE ACTUALLY PRINTING YOUR PORTFOLIO

Use 612×792pt instead, true 8.5×11in Letter, the size in every printer tray. The page itself still divides cleanly by 12 ($792 / 12 = 66$). Under the same margins used tonight, rows don't divide as cleanly (78pt, 6.5 baseline units). Fix it by enlarging the bottom margin to 96pt, which restores whole 72pt rows, 6 baseline units each. This week's reading, "Every Number in the Grid," walks through the full comparison.

Everyone Else

Stick with 600×840pt. It's not wrong, it's the version built for learning the system fast, not for a specific paper tray.

Grid Checklist

Confirm every item before you consider tonight's setup finished.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Leading chosen first: 12pt |
| 2 | Document size is a multiple of the leading: 600 × 840pt |
| 3 | Margins are multiples of 12: 36 / 48 / 36 / 36 |
| 4 | Baseline grid on, view threshold set to 25% so it stays visible |
| 5 | Row math checked by hand before Create Guides: 63 lines, no remainder |
| 6 | 6 columns, 8 rows, 12pt gutters, every row lands on a baseline line |

Quick Reference

Keep this open while you work.

ACTION	MAC	WINDOWS
Toggle Baseline Grid	Cmd + Opt + '	Ctrl + Alt + '
Preview Mode	W	W
Show/Hide Guides	Cmd + ;	Ctrl + ;
Snap to Guides	Shift + Cmd + ;	Shift + Ctrl + ;
Fit Spread in Window	Opt + Cmd + 0	Alt + Ctrl + 0